

Genre: Simulation
Studio: Virtual Heroes,
 Army Game Studio
Publishers: NASA
Platform: Windows

Moonbase Alpha is developed by NASA and you play an "astronaut working to further human expansion and research." Unlike most games, there are no extraterrestrial locations, no monsters, your "enemies" are the forces of the universe and time itself. Your "weapons" are the tools of any astronaut's trade, a welding machine, a wrench... Fortunately, in space no one can hear you yawn.

The Moonbase Alpha game story is a set in the near future, the year 2025, shortly after the standardisation of HTML5 – just kidding! In 2020, NASA begins construction of a lunar base at the south pole of the Moon. In 2025, when the game is set, the lunar base has just become self-sustaining, and everything is set for further expansion

to "other areas of the Moon, to Mars and beyond."

Your aim is to repair the damage to your station's power supply before Oxygen runs out. You accomplish this by hobbling along at a realistically depicted, yet annoyingly slow pace carrying one tool at a time to weld power couplers, secure cables, repair solar panels, use a robot to repair the life support systems and use rovers to transport equipment and people. A welding mini-game launches each time you start a repair.

The game is designed around a multi-player experience, and you can join public games on the intranet, or those created by your friends, LAN gaming is another option. Moonbase Alpha can as easily be played single player as it can be played in a multi-player game. When you choose to create a new game, you get an option to select the settlement size based on the number of players playing (1-2, 3-4, 5-6). You can play in both a "Competitive Mode" which poses a time limit and improves your stats, or a free play mode. You can create a password protected game, or

play in offline mode.

The game graphics are nice, with each footstep you take leaving impressions on the lunar soil, however the game has little in the way of sound. Understandable since you are in space. The voice acting for the short cinematic sequence in the beginning of the game is rather dull, and emotionless. The team at Moonbase Alpha tells talks about their impending deaths from suffocation a little too matter-of-factly.

Somewhere deep down we think this game was meant to inspire people and interest them in the wonders of space, but the fact is, unless you are already interested you're just likely to get bored. Let us end this by saying something which might seem very contrary to the impression we have built up till now: Moon Base Alpha is a brilliant game. If you are one of the few people who are attracted to space for what it is, a vast expanse of stuff waiting for exploration; which is likely to be a slow, redundant, and trying process, you may enjoy this game immensely. **d**

**LUNAR PERIL:
 DUTY CALLS**

We waited for the alien attack, but it never came,
 then I waited for the machine uprising, but no cake.
 What is it about a game that you expect a constant
 state of doom?

